

FIREWALL

With Internet usage going up, both for dial-up users and for those who have access to broadband and cable Internet services, the susceptibility to hackers will also go up. Thus it becomes imperative for those who are hooked on to the Net to install a firewall which protects against Trojans and other tools used by hackers.

Using a personal firewall software nowadays is easy. All you have to do is run the installer and in a few minutes the applications will warn you about possible vulnerabilities on your system and block any intrusions that you might otherwise be oblivious to.

Firewalls are going to be a very critical component of computers due to the proliferation of Internet-based threats. Therefore, more and more operating systems are going to integrate some form of a Firewall directly into the operating system. On the enterprise front, Firewalls are going to evolve into much more robust applications that could even use heuristics and some form of artificial intelligence.



Zone Alarm Pro 2.6



This firewall offers the best combination of protection and ease of use

This software performed well in all parameters. Though it did not have support for ActiveX controls, it had a good set of features which protect the PC from Trojans, automatically block known and unknown threats from the Internet, and also prevent hackers from stealing your data by making you invisible to them. What's also important is that this software is relatively easy to install, configure and manage even for a novice.

- + Extremely easy to configure
- + Provides good protection

Price: Free for download
Contact: Zone Labs
Web site: www.zonelabs.com
Reviewed in: June 2001

Worthy Mentions

Norton Personal Firewall 2001

+ Provides good security and protection from intruders
Price: Not available
Contact: Tech Pacific
Phone: 022-5960238
Fax: 022-5960102
E-mail: adil@techpacificindia.com
Web site: www.symantec.com
Reviewed in: September 2001

eSafe Desktop

+ Has its own integrated anti-virus scanner
 + Free for personal use
Price: Free for personal use
Contact: Aladdin Knowledge Systems
Web site: www.esafe.com
Reviewed in: September 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: Norton Personal Firewall 2000 1999: NA 1998: NA

IMAGE EDITING SOFTWARE

Image editing software is one area where developers have focussed on adding more functionality to make it easier for designers to work. The inclusion of support for vector images now puts them into a space that was earlier occupied by specialised software for illustration. In addition to providing newer filters that we have come to expect, certain packages like Photoshop have managed to improve on an already impressive feature set. Traditional image editors continue to improve on their ability to manage text effectively and are adding support for newer file formats. The latest releases from Adobe include tools that make it easier to create optimised output for the Web also.

All this indicates a consolidation of sorts taking place amongst image editing suites over the next couple of years. This would mean that a designer, instead of having to switch between different packages to perform specific tasks, would now be able to use a single suite to perform the complete range of tasks. Furthermore, tools for designers will offer features that make it easier to collaborate.



Photoshop 6.01



Photoshop is now the best image editing software for both print and Web output

Photoshop 6.01 is an extremely powerful package for graphic designers. It is extremely easy to use, has a huge list of filters to enhance images and now has support for vector objects, which makes it the best solution for digital image editing. Other nice touches are the improved layer management, a new Styles palette that lets you reuse preset special effects, some collaboration-friendly features, and the vastly improved text handling.

+ Better layer management; simpler text controls
 + Includes vector support
Price: Rs 39,456
Contact: Adobe Systems (I) Pvt Ltd

Phone: 0118-4532026
Fax: 0118-4532010
E-mail: sandeepm@adobe.com
Web site: www.adobe.com
Reviewed in: October 2001

Worthy Mentions

JASC Paintshop Pro 7

+ Can generate animations
 + Good set of filters
 + Competitively priced
Price: Rs 5,995
Contact: The Bird Group
Phone: 011-3329199
Fax: 011-6142999
E-mail: alpna.chaturvedi@the-birdgroup.com
Reviewed in: October 2001

Gimp 1.2 Windows

+ Provides good functionalities with regard to image editing capabilities
 + Free for use
Price: Free for download
Contact: Gimp
Web site: www.gimp.org
Reviewed in: October 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: NA 1999: Adobe Photoshop 5.0 1998: Adobe Photoshop 5.0